Mockingbird

By Kathryn Erskine

(Pg 34) Sometimes I read the same books over and over and over. What's great about books is that the stuff inside doesn't change. People say you can't judge a book by its cover but that's not true because it says right on the cover what's inside And no matter how many times you read that book the words and pictures don't change You can open and close books a million times and they stay the same. They look the same. They say the same words. Books are not like people. Books are safe.

INTRODUCTION

In Caitlin's world everything is black and white. Anything in between is confusing. That's the stuff her brother, Devon, always explained. But now Devon is dead, and Caitlin's dad cries . . . A LOT. She wants to help, but as a ten-year-old girl with Asperger's syndrome, she doesn't know how. Then one day, on the news, she hears the word CLOsure and her life's goal becomes a quest to find just that.

Mockingbird by Kathryn Erskine, who's own daughter, Fiona, has Asperger's as well.

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(Pg 10-16) Dad says it's time to go back to school so here I am. Back in Mrs. Brook's room. Sitting at the little round table. Mrs Brook says people have a hard time understanding me because I have Asperger's so I have to try extra hard to understand them and that means working on emotions.

MRS. BROOK: Hi, Caitlin. So how are you? How are you feeling? *(Caitlin sighs heavily and avoids making eye contact with Mrs. Brook)* I think you'd like to forget about the painful events you've been through. The funeral must have been very difficult.

I wonder what she means. We sat in church. It was not very difficult. Everyone spoke so quietly I could barely hear them and almost no one talked to me. No one laughed like crashing glass and there was no lightning movement and no one appeared out of nowhere and nothing happened suddenly.

MRS. BROOK: Let's Talk About it. *(Caitlin turns her head away so she can't see Mrs. Brooks anymore)* I know it's

difficult but you can't keep it all inside. Did you cry at the funeral?

CAITLIN: *(Shaking her head)* Dad cried. Please stop asking me questions.

MRS. BROOK: Caitlin. Your father is sad.

CAITLIN: Why?

MRS. BROOK: He misses Devon.

CAITLIN: Oh. MISS is a strange word. There is MISS like MISS Harper the principal. There is MISS like you will MISS your bus if you don't hurry because you have to step on every crack. And there is MISS like dead.

MRS. BROOK: You'll miss [Devon] but he'll always be with you. Just in a different way.

I don't want him around in a different way. I want him around in the same way. The way he was before. When he makes me popcorn and hot chocolate. And he tells me what to say and what clothes to wear and how not to be weird so kids won't laugh at me. That's the Devon I want. Not one who is floating around in the air.

(Pg 63) At home I think about Devon's Heart. I close my eyes and remember some of the things that happened

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on The Day Our Life Fell Apart. That's what Dad calls it. After we came home from the hospital that night – with no Devon – Dad was yelling and kicking the furniture and the walls and shouting. Why? Why? WHY? Until I screamed at him: STOP IT! STOP IT! STOP IT!

I press myself against the sofa and squish my eyes tight and even though I try not to I remember being at the hospital. People dressed in green pajamas and paper slippers said to Dad:

DOCTOR: We tried but we couldn't close your son's chest. His Heart – there was nothing left – there was nothing we could do. Nothing we could do.

(Pg 37) A gunshot wound to the Heart is almost always fatal. **(Pg 65-71)** [Dad] comes back into the living room and turns on the TV and stands there looking at it.

NEWS REPORTER: *(with a microphone in his hand)* I'm at the courthouse where the remaining killer from the Virginia Dare Middle School shooting has just had his preliminary hearing. The hearing found that there's enough evidence against him to be put on trial for the murders of teacher Roberta Schneider and young

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students Julieanne Morris and Devon Smith. That horrific shooting was a devastating blow to this small community.

Dad goes to the bathroom and throws up. The camera switches to a lady sitting inside at the news desk.

LADY: We'll hear more about this story later but isn't it good that we now have closure.

I don't think there is anything good about any of it. And I wonder how CLOsure can help. And what it is. I look up CLOsure and it says: ***the state of experiencing an emotional conclusion to a difficult life event such as the death of a loved one.*** I squeeze my Dictionary tight against my chest. I can hear Dad crying, so I close my eyes and plug my ears. [The next day] I wait all morning for my Mrs. Brook time. *(to Mrs. Brook)* Closure. How do I find it?

MRS. BROOK: Caitlin. Is this . . . are you talking about the news? The boy from the shooting? *(she clasps her hands together, takes a deep breath and lets it out. Slowly. She closes her eyes)*

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CAITLIN: *(to audience)* Is she praying? *(to Mrs. Brooks)* This isn't church.

MRS. BROOKS: I know. I'm thinking. Sometimes the process of a funeral and burial and doing things like putting wreaths on grave sites help give Closure.

CAITLIN: Devon was cremated so that will not work for me.

MRS. BROOKS: Sometimes talking can help both you [and your Dad] a lot. Talking about your feelings.

CAITLIN: That will not work for me. I don't like Let's Talk About It. – Is there anything else? *(to audience)* I start shaking my hands because the world is spinning and if I shake my hands faster than the rest of the world then the world's spinning doesn't seem so fast.

MRS. BROOKS: It's something you have to find for yourself because everyone is different. We all have to find our own special way.

CAITLIN: *(with a big sigh.)* Fine. I will figure it out myself.

(Pg 74-80) When Dad drives me home from school, I stand in front of Devon's door. Whenever I don't know what to do I go to Devon's room and ask him. I REALLY want to know about Closure. Except Devon's not here. But

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his room is. I haven't been inside since Dad slammed the door on The Day Our Life Fell Apart. When I push my head into the soft blue blur of his room I can smell him and feel him. *(Smiling)* It's like pure Devon in here. I see it. My hidey-hole. The best place in the world. The corner between the foot of his bed and his dresser. He even used his Boy Scout knife to carve my name underneath his dresser. *(crouching down to see the underneath side of the dresser, Caitlin runs her fingers over her name)*

It's not my real name. It's Devon's name for me which is Scout. It's from To Kill a Mockingbird. It has two kids in it: Jem and Scout. They are a brother and a sister. The first time we watched To Kill a Mockingbird I waited through the whole movie for the dad to shoot a mockingbird. No one shot a bird for the whole entire movie. Devon said the title makes perfect sense and this is what it means:

DEVON: ***It's wrong to shoot someone who is innocent and was never going to hurt you in the first place. You shouldn't hurt innocent people Scout. That's what it means.***

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I guess the evil school shooters didn't listen in English class because they did not Get the meaning of that book at all. **(Pg 148)** [A few days later] my class goes to the computer lab. Mrs. Johnson says we have free time and can look up any topic we want to learn more about as long as it's not computer games. I remember I should be researching Closure so I look it up and this is what I find: ***the act of bringing to an end; a conclusion – example: They finally brought the project to closure.*** I see Devon's Eagle Scout project in my head. **(Pg 2)** It's the chest Dad and Devon are making so he'll be ready to teach other Boy Scouts how to build a chest. **(Pg 149)** I think about how much he wanted to finish it and become an Eagle Scout. And how he was going to teach me how to do woodworking too. And then I start shaking my hands fast and my heart is pounding in my ears. *(Caitlin begins moaning)*

MRS. JOHNSON: Caitlin are you all right?

CAITLIN: *(Screaming loud enough for Devon to hear up in Heaven)* I GET IT! I GET IT! I GET IT! I GET IT! *(long pause, then, to audience)* Now I know how to

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experience an emotional conclusion to a difficult life event.

TRANSITION

As excited as Caitlin is about finishing Devon's Eagle Scout project, it's difficult for her dad.

CAITLIN: **(Pg 162-163)** *(to audience)* Dad sighs and looks at the sheet covered chest in the corner for the first time ever and I want to start shaking my hands but I know that does not make Dad happy so I sit on them instead. *(to Dad)* Dad, I want to finish the chest. I want to get to Closure.

DAD: *(quietly)* I know

CAITLIN: You need to get to Closure too. *(Dad nods) (To audience)* I think about what Devon would say. *(To Dad)* You have to Work At It Dad. You have to try even if it's hard and you think you can never do it and you just want to scream and hide and shake your hands over and over and over.

DAD: *(wipes his eyes, as his body begins to shake with controlled sobs. He covers his face with his hands and tries to compose himself. He sniffs twice and then turns to Caitlin)* How did you get to be so smart?

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CAITLIN: *(Shrugging)* I'm really working hard on finesse.

DAD: Do you really want to do this? You think this will bring us Closure.

CAITLIN: *(shaking her head)* No. I know it will.

DAD: *(Blowing a little air out of his nose, he nods and sighs heavily)* Maybe we can make something good and strong and beautiful come out of this.

CAITLIN: *(To audience)* Good and strong and beautiful. I like those words. They sound like Devon.

DAD: Okay. Let's do it.

CAITLIN: **(Pg 202-204)** *(to Dad)* Do you remember that movie?

DAD: What movie?

CAITLIN: To Kill a Mockingbird. It's a good one isn't it?

DAD: It's been a long time since I've seen it but it was one of the best.

CAITLIN: Devon liked it too.

DAD: *(clearing his throat and clenching and unclenching his hand)* Yes, he did.

CAITLIN: Do you think I'm like Scout?

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DAD: The little girl in the movie? *(nods)* Very much.

CAITLIN: You're like Atticus. He was brave.

DAD: Thank you. *(sighs again)* I wish I were more like Atticus. [But] Honey . . . we have to live in the real world. I like you as Caitlin.

CAITLIN: But you said the movie was the best.

DAD: For a movie. But this is real life. A movie isn't as good as real life. It can't even compare.

CAITLIN: *(To audience)* Dad is wrong about that. A movie is better than real life because in the movies only the bad guys die . . . .

TRANSITION

And so the work on Devon's Eagle Scout Project – Devon's Chest begins

CAITLIN: **(Pg 187-188)** What is a Dad-oh?

DAD: *(smiling a half smile)* Day-doe. And it's a grove in a piece of wood.

CAITLIN: *(To audience)* He is staring to smile. I know what that means. Closure must be coming! . . . So I Work At It *(to Dad)* I like Dad-oh better. Here's the

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screwdriver, Dad-oh. Would you like a glass of water, Dad-oh? Can I help you, Dad-oh?

And his lips curl up on the left side every time. Closure is a very good thing to see. After Dad-oh goes to bed, I sneak into Devon's room and borrow his Boy Scout knife. I slide my head under the chest and look for the perfect spot. I carve in big letters on his chest, just like Devon did for me: SCOUT!

(Pg 212) [We worked on it together for weeks and now] our chest is almost done. I draw what I want to carve into the top part of it. The bird is gray and black and white and has a long tail. Her head is tilted up and her beak is open like she's singing. She is beautiful. I run to the living room to show it to Dad.

DAD: *(taking the drawing with one hand and rubbing his chin with the other – puzzled)* It's not . . . It doesn't look [like an] eagle.

CAITLIN: It's not an eagle. It's a mockingbird.

DAD: *(tiling his head to one side)* I thought it was an eagle because this is Devon's Eagle Scout project.

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CAITLIN: It's a mockingbird . . . like in the movie. Remember? Because Devon was like Jem. And I'm like Scout. And you Dad – you're like Atticus. **(Pg 218-219)** *(Caitlin suddenly begins to cry and can't stop)* Dad-oh! Dad! Oh Dad!

DAD: *(pushing the hair from Caitlin's face)* What is it Caitlin?

CAITLIN: *(between sobs)* Devon . . . . Devon.

DAD: I know. It hurts. You miss him. I miss him.

CAITLIN: But I'm not crying for ME! I'm crying for Devon! I'm crying because I feel bad for HIM!

DAD: *(smiling through his own tears)* Now you know what it's like to feel for other people.

CAITLIN: *(To audience)* I look over at Devon's chest and it makes me feel good. *(to Dad)* We did a great job on it, didn't we Dad? We made something good and strong and beautiful.

DAD: *(nodding)* We sure did. Devon would be very proud.

I nod too. I think about Devon and how he would show it to all the Scouts and tell everyone how we made it and how we used it to find Closure. That's when I feel my

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mouth turn into a grin and my hands start shaking so hard I have to leap off the sofa and jump around the room because just shaking my hands isn't enough for all the excitement. . . I finally Get it! I Get It! I GET IT!

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Kathryn Erskine
ISBN: 978-0399252648
Publisher: Philomel
Date (Month/Year): Apr 2010

AWARD HISTORY

2011 National Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

NOTE: An overview of the signs and symptoms of Asperger's can be found here
http://blog.brainbalance.com/blog/2012/02/signs-and-symptoms-of-asperger-syndrome

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